

“To The Lighthouse” by Virginia Woolf

[B2]

Una semplice gita in barca viene ostacolata dal maltempo, dal destino e dalla guerra. Ma la trama è solo il pretesto per parlare delle emozioni, dei ricordi e dei pensieri più intimi dei protagonisti.



To the Lighthouse is a pioneering modernist novel by Virginia Woolf. Published in 1927, the book combines powerful autobiographical elements with Woolf's observations on relationships, art, life, [loss](#), and the nature of perception. Written in three parts, To the Lighthouse opens in the early 1910s on the Isle of Skye in Scotland at the summer home of the Ramsay family. With little [plot](#), dialogue or direct action, the story is told in a [stream-of-consciousness](#) style across time and through the thoughts and observations of its characters. When six-year-old James asks if they can [sail](#) to the [nearby](#) lighthouse, his mother supports the idea. Mr. Ramsay, however, [warns](#) that the [weather forecast](#) is not good. "No going to the Lighthouse, James," he said, as he stood by the window, speaking awkwardly, but trying in deference to Mrs. Ramsay to soften his voice into some semblance of geniality at least. Odious little man, thought Mrs. Ramsay, why go on saying that? "Perhaps you will wake up and find the sun shining and the birds singing," she said compassionately, smoothing the little boy's hair, for her husband, with his caustic saying that it would not be fine, had dashed his spirits, she could see.

"«Non si va al Faro, James» disse, mentre era in piedi accanto alla finestra; parlava con fare imbarazzato, pur cercando — per rispetto alla signora Ramsay — di addolcire il tono in modo che sembrasse quantomeno cordiale. Che ometto odioso, pensò la signora Ramsay, perché insisteva nel dire quella cosa? «Forse ti sveglierai e troverai il sole che splende e gli uccellini che cantano» disse compassionevole, accarezzando i capelli del bambino, perché il marito, con quel suo annuncio caustico che non avrebbe fatto bello, l'aveva demoralizzato, lo vedeva bene.»

Virginia Woolf in 1938.

LOVING FEELING

As they [argue](#), the parents show their different [approaches](#) to life. Rational and intellectual, Mr. Ramsay studies and writes philosophy. Mrs. Ramsay uses feelings and intuition and is protective of her family. She is introspective, while Mr. Ramsay says what he feels. Like many marriages, theirs involves [compromise](#). "He found talking so much easier than she did. He could say things — she never could [...] It was only that she never could say what she felt [...] And as she looked at him she began to smile, for though she had not said a word, he knew, of course he knew, that she loved him. He could not deny it. And smiling, she looked out of the window and said (thinking to herself 'Nothing on earth can equal this happiness') — 'Yes, you were right. It's going to be wet tomorrow.'" "Per lui parlare era molto più facile di quanto non lo fosse per lei. Lui sapeva dirle, le cose; lei no. [...] Era solo che non riusciva mai a dire quel che provava. [...] E mentre lo guardava cominciò a sorridere, perché anche se lei non aveva detto una parola, lui sapeva — lo sapeva di certo — che lei l'amava. Non poteva negarlo. E sorridendo guardò fuori dalla finestra e disse (pensando tra sé, Niente al mondo potrà mai eguagliare questa felicità) — «Sì, avevi ragione. Domani pioverà»." Classic Books

“Mrs. Dalloway” by Virginia Woolf L’emblematica opera di Virginia Woolf, che si svolge in un solo giorno nella Londra degli anni Venti, continua a sedurre i lettori con una narrazione sperimentale basata sul flusso di coscienza dei protagonisti. Alex Warner, Sarah Davison

EMPTY HOUSE

The second part of the book reflects on the effect of war and [hardship](#) on life in Britain — and on the Ramsay family. We [learn](#) that Mrs. Ramsay has died, as well as her daughter Prue (in [childbirth](#)) and son Andrew (in World War One.) On the island, their [empty](#) holiday home reflects the feelings of [loss](#): “The house was left; the house was deserted. It was left like a shell on a sandhill to fill with dry salt grains now that life had left it [...] The saucepan had rusted and the mat decayed. Toads had nosed their way in. Idly, aimlessly, the swaying shawl swung to and fro. A thistle thrust itself between the tiles in the larder. The swallows nested in the drawing-room; the floor was strewn with straw; the plaster fell in shovelfuls; rafters were laid bare; rats carried off this and that to gnaw behind the wainscots.” British troops awaiting the order to attack, Western Front, First World War, c.1916 “La casa venne abbandonata; non ci andò più nessuno. Fu abbandonata come una conchiglia su una duna di sabbia a riempirsi di granelli di sale, ora che la vita l’aveva abbandonata. [...] La pentola si era arrugginita e la stuoia disfatta. I rospi s’erano fatti strada all’interno. Pigro, senza scopo, lo scialle aveva oscillato avanti e indietro, dondolante. Un cardo era cresciuto tra le mattonelle nella dispensa. Le rondini avevano fatto il nido in salotto; il pavimento era cosparso di paglia; l’intonaco cadeva a palate; le travi erano rimaste nude; i topi si portavano via questo e quello per rosicchiarlo dietro il battiscopa.”

RETURN

In the novel’s final section, ten years after we first meet them, the family returns to Skye. Everything is, as Mr. Ramsay remarks, “much changed.” When he suggests a boat trip to the lighthouse, his daughter Cam and son James join him. The boat [sails](#) out to sea, everyone lost in their thoughts. James [steers skilfully](#) through the waves, and as they arrive at their destination, unexpectedly receives his father’s [praise](#): “Then, having lighted his pipe, he took out his watch. He looked at it attentively; he made, perhaps, some mathematical calculation. At last he said, triumphantly: ‘Well done!’ James had steered them like a born [sailor](#). ‘There!’ Cam thought, addressing herself silently to James. ‘You’ve got it at last.’” “Poi, accesa la pipa, tirò fuori l’orologio. Lo guardò con attenzione; forse fece qualche calcolo matematico. Alla fine, trionfante, disse: «Molto bene!» James aveva manovrato la barca come un marinaio provetto. Ecco! Pensò Cam, rivolgendosi in silenzio a James. Ce l’hai fatta alla fine.”

COMPLEXITIES

Described by Woolf as a “psychological poem”, *To the Lighthouse* examines the complexities of human experience and the difference in the masculine and feminine attitudes of the author’s time in clear, [striking](#) prose. The novel received excellent reviews and sold well. Woolf said it was “easily the best of my books.”

Glossary

- **argue** = discutere
- **childbirth** = parto
- **empty** = vuota
- **steers** = manovrare il timone
- **praise** = elogio
- **loss** = perdita
- **plot** = trama
- **stream-of-consciousness** = flusso di coscienza
- **sail** = navigare
- **approaches** = approcci
- **compromise** = compromesso
- **hardship** = difficoltà
- **warns** = avvertire
- **nearby** = vicino
- **weather forecast** = previsioni meteo
- **learn** = apprendere
- **skilfully** = abilmente
- **striking** = di forte impatto